

It is the small town, the small city, that is our heritage. We have made twentieth-century America from it, and some account of these communities as they were ... we owe our children and grandchildren.^[6]

American historian Hampton Sides wrote in *Americana: Dispatches from the New Frontier*:

The United States of America is such a glorious mess of contradiction, such a crazy quilt of competing themes, such a fecund mishmash of people and ideas, that defining us is pretty much pointless. There is, of course, a kind of faded notion of "Americana", one that concerns Route 66, diners, freak rock formations, and the like—but even in its halcyon days this "roadside attraction" version of America was never an accurate or nuanced distillation of our massively complicated culture.

There are scenes and places, wattages and personages, that belong—inextricably, unmistakably—to this country alone. There is an American quality, a tone, an energy ... instantly recognizable ..."^[7]

Many kinds of cultural artifacts fall within the definition of Americana: the things involved need not be old, but are usually associated with some quintessential element of the American experience. Each period of United States history is reflected by the advertising and marketing of the time, and the various types of antiques, collectibles, memorabilia and vintage items from these time periods are typical of what is popularly considered Americana. The Atlantic described the term as "slang for the comforting, middle-class ephemera at your average antique store—things like needle-pointed pillows, Civil War daguerreotypes, and engraved silverware sets".^[8]

The nostalgia for this period was based on a remembrance of confidence in American life that had emerged during the period due to such factors as a sense that the frontier had finally been "conquered", with the U.S. Census Bureau's declaration that it was "closed" in 1890, as well as the recent victory in the Spanish-American War.^[5] By 1912, the contiguous United States was at last fully politically incorporated, and the idea of the nation as a single, solid unity could begin to take hold.

As Canby put it,

Americans at this time "really believed all they heard on the Fourth of July or read in school readers. They set on one plane of time, and that the present, the Declaration of Independence, the manifest destiny of America, the new plumbing, the growth of the factory system, the morning paper, and the church sociable. It was all there at once, better than elsewhere, their own, and permanent. ... They had just the country they wanted...and they believed it would be the same, except for more bathtubs and faster trains, forever ... for the last time in living memory everyone knew exactly what it meant to be an American."^[6]

On growing up Italian-American, novelist Don DeLillo stated:

It's no accident that my first novel was called Americana. This was a private declaration of independence, a statement of my intention to use the whole picture, the whole culture. America was and is the immigrant's dream, and as the son of two immigrants I was attracted by the sense of possibility that had drawn my grandparents and parents.

The zeitgeist of this idealized period is captured in the Disneyland theme park's Main Street, U.S.A. section (which was inspired by both Walt Disney's hometown of Marceline, Missouri and Harper Goff's childhood home of Fort Collins, Colorado),^[10] as well as the musical and movie *The Music Man* and Thornton Wilder's stage play *Our Town*.^[5] Especially revered in nostalgic Americana are small-town institutions like the barber shop,^[11] drug store, soda fountain and ice cream parlor;^[12] some of these were eventually resurrected by mid-twentieth century nostalgia for the time period in businesses like the Farrell's Ice Cream Parlour chain, with its 1890s theme.^[13]

Examples

Cultural symbols

- The Statue of Liberty
- The U.S. flag, and Old Glory in particular
- "The Star-Spangled Banner"
- The Fourth of July
- Apple pie
- Cowboy
- Baseball
- Cheerleading
- White picket fence^[14]
- Religious camp meeting^[15]
- Tent revival^[15]

Brand names

- Coca-Cola^{[16][17]}
- Levi's blue jeans, especially Levi's 501s^{[17][18]}
- Budweiser
- Jim Beam
- Jack Daniel's
- Marlboro
- Harley-Davidson
- Ford
- Chevrolet
- Nike

See also

- History of immigration to the United States
- Culture of the United States
- Folklore of the United States
- History of the United States

- American studies
- Transcendentalism
- Romanticism
- Black Americana

Similar concepts

- Australiana, for cultural artifacts from Australia
- Canadiana, for cultural artifacts from Canada
- Communist nostalgia, a similar concept in former or currently communist countries
- Floridiana, artifacts relating to the state of Florida.
- Hawaiiana, Native Hawaiian cultural artifacts from the U.S. state of Hawaii.
- Kiwiana, for cultural artifacts from New Zealand (Kiwi being a nickname for New Zealanders).
- Ostalgie, a similar concept in East Germany
- PRL nostalgia, a similar concept in Poland
- Rhodesiana, a similar concept in Zimbabwe relating to items made in its colonial (Rhodesia) era
- Soviet nostalgia, a similar concept in the former Soviet Union
- Yugo-nostalgia, a similar concept in the former Yugoslav states

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External links

- Merriam-Webster definition of "Americana" (<https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/Americana>)

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